Coffee, ready-to-drink: HMTc Standard

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CORRESPONDENCE

Corrections are logged publicly on the article page, each with its date, the affected value, and the source that resolved it.

KEYWORDS

heavy metals, food safety, dietary exposure

PUBLICATION HISTORY

This revision 2026-08.

Abstract

The Heavy Metal Tested & Certified heavy-metal-safety standard for ready-to-drink coffee in Beverages (canned and bottled coffee, cold-brew and nitro coffee, ready-to-drink coffee drinks), evaluated on the liquid as consumed at single strength. Every panel analyte carries a limit: eight numeric ceilings (Hong Kong's direct coffee-beverage lead limit, the drinking-water quality standards read across for the water-borne metals, and the canned-beverage tin limit) plus three species bounded by their parent total. The dry coffee commodity is certified separately in its own as-sold basis; the two bases are never mixed.

1 | How every number on this standard is set

HMTc Method v2.0 (government-limit-only): the strictest applicable sovereign maximum level for this exact beverage form and analyte in the row's declared native basis, with disclosed read-across where the exact cell is unregulated, a substantiated not-material determination where a species is bounded or is a method artifact, and a control where no defensible sovereign number and no supportable near-neighbour exist. Never occurrence-derived. Ready-to-drink and dry-commodity bases are never mixed and no brewing, dilution or reconstitution factor is invented.

2 | Master limit table

All values in ppb (µg/kg), as consumed basis. A brand meeting every value qualifies for the mark.

ANALYTE	HMTC LIMIT	BASIS

Lead (Pb)	200	government maximum level (Hong Kong)
Cadmium (Cd)	2	read-across (AU)
Total arsenic (tAs)	10	read-across (European Union)
Inorganic arsenic (iAs)	≤ tAs	bounded by tAs (reflex speciation)
Mercury, total (tHg)	1	read-across (European Union)
Methylmercury (MeHg)	≤ tHg	bounded by tHg (reflex speciation)
Nickel (Ni)	20	read-across (European Union)
Tin (Sn)	100,000	read-across (EU 2023/915)
Aluminium (Al)	200	read-across (European Union)
Total chromium (Cr)	50	read-across (AU)
Hexavalent chromium (Cr-VI)	10	read-across (CA SWRCB)

3 | Derivation — where each number comes from

Every cell traces to one named sovereign maximum level (the strictest for the nearest analog), or to an explicit control, not-material, or species-bounded determination. No occurrence statistic selects a certification value.

ANALYTE	HMTC	SOVEREIGN ANALOG / DETERMINATION
Lead (Pb)	200	government maximum level (Hong Kong)
Cadmium (Cd)	2	read-across (AU); drinking water
Total arsenic (tAs)	10	read-across (European Union); water intended for human consumption
Inorganic arsenic (iAs)	≤ tAs	bounded by tAs (reflex speciation)
Mercury, total (tHg)	1	read-across (European Union); water intended for human consumption
Methylmercury (MeHg)	≤ tHg	bounded by tHg (reflex speciation)
Nickel (Ni)	20	read-across (European Union); water intended for human consumption

Tin (Sn)	100,000	read-across (EU 2023/915); canned beverages, including canned fruit and vegetable juices, except canned dried and canned powdered products
Aluminium (Al)	200	read-across (European Union); water intended for human consumption
Total chromium (Cr)	50	read-across (AU); drinking water
Hexavalent chromium (Cr-VI)	10	read-across (CA SWRCB); public water systems in California

4 | Cite this standard

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References

[1] Hong Kong
Binds Pb.
MAXIMUM LEVEL

[2] AU
Binds Cd, Cr. drinking water.
READ-ACROSS

[3] European Union
Binds tAs, tHg, Ni, Al. water intended for human consumption.
READ-ACROSS

[4] CA SWRCB
Binds Cr-VI. public water systems in California.
READ-ACROSS

[5] EU 2023/915
Binds Sn. canned beverages, including canned fruit and vegetable juices, except canned dried and canned powdered products.
READ-ACROSS

STATUS AND LICENCE

A normative certification standard, editorially reviewed and version-controlled in-house; every value traces to a named sovereign maximum level, disclosed in the derivation. © 2026 Institute of Contaminant Standards / Heavy Metal Certified. All rights reserved.

COMPETING INTERESTS

This standard is published by the Heavy Metal Tested & Certified (HMTc) program, operated by the Institute of Contaminant Standards. Its statements about government regulations, toxicology, and occurrence are sourced to the cited primary and expert-body records and to the independently maintained Heavy Metal Index; the program's

own certification thresholds are not used as evidence for any factual claim made here.

DATA AVAILABILITY

The works this standard draws on are listed in full in the references above and on the standard page at https://heavymetalcertified.com/standards/coffee-ready-to-drink. Primary legal instruments and expert-body assessments are named with their public identifiers; the underlying occurrence and toxicology corpus is maintained on the Heavy Metal Index.

PUBLICATION HISTORY

This revision 2026-08. The full dated record is maintained at https://heavymetalcertified.com/standards/coffee-ready-to-drink.

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